

# Plague — What you need to know

*A bacterial infection from infected rodents and their fleas — treatable when caught early*

Plague is a bacterial infection (*Yersinia pestis*) that lives in wild rodents — in Arizona, especially prairie dogs, ground squirrels, and chipmunks in the northern part of the state (Coconino, Apache, and Navajo counties). It can spread to humans and pets through infected fleas, by handling sick or dead animals, or rarely through respiratory droplets from sick cats. **Plague is fully treatable with antibiotics if caught early — but is rapidly fatal if not treated.**

## Symptoms

- Sudden high fever and chills
- Severe headache
- Painful, swollen lymph nodes (called 'buboes') in the groin, armpit, or neck
- Extreme weakness
- Cough with bloody sputum (in pneumonic plague — rare but dangerous)

## What you should do

1. Get to a doctor or emergency room immediately. Time matters.
2. Take antibiotics exactly as prescribed — usually streptomycin, gentamicin, or doxycycline for at least 10 days.
3. If you have pneumonic plague (cough with bloody sputum), follow isolation precautions until you have been on antibiotics for at least 48 hours.
4. Treat all pets in the household for fleas. Cats are particularly susceptible to plague and can give it to humans.
5. Avoid contact with wild rodents or rodent burrows. Do not let pets hunt prairie dogs or ground squirrels.

### If your cat was diagnosed first

Cats with plague can transmit the infection to humans through respiratory droplets, particularly to veterinarians and family members caring for the sick cat. **If your cat was diagnosed with plague, contact your doctor right away — even before you have symptoms.** Your doctor may give you preventive antibiotics. Veterinarians and household contacts of cats with plague have been documented sources of human cases.

## Recovery

With prompt antibiotic treatment, most people recover fully. Untreated plague has a 30–60% death rate. The earlier antibiotics start, the better the outcome.

**Call 911 immediately if you have:**

- Sudden severe fever after exposure to wild rodents or sick pets
- Painful swollen lump in groin, armpit, or neck with fever
- Coughing up blood
- A pet (especially a cat) that died unexpectedly with fever

**More information**

- Arizona Department of Health Services Vector-borne Disease Program: 602-364-4562
- CDC Plague page: [cdc.gov/plague](https://www.cdc.gov/plague)
- Coconino County Health Department: 928-679-7272

*ONE-HealthRecord MVP · Synthetic demonstration · Content drawn from public CDC and Arizona Department of Health Services plain-language disease pages. This handout is informational and does not replace medical advice from your clinician.*